

AR.4 Where to File Directory

How to find out whether anybody permits your parcel — and the offices that exist even when nobody does.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Arkansas adopts one building code for the whole state and forbids your city or county from adopting a different one — and then requires nobody to enforce it on a house. The building permit, the inspections and the certificate of occupancy exist only where a city or a county chose to create them, and across most unincorporated Arkansas nobody did. What does not depend on that choice is the code itself, the onsite wastewater permit, and the trade licensing rules. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it. Every web address here was checked in September 2026. Offices move; the method in the next section outlives any list.

THERE IS NO LIST — SO HERE IS THE METHOD

Some states publish a register of which jurisdictions enforce the building code. **Arkansas does not.** No state agency maintains a list of which of the 75 counties and several hundred municipalities issue residential building permits, because no state agency has any reason to: the decision is local, permissive, and nobody has to report it to anyone.

That sounds like bad news and is actually manageable, because the answer is sitting in plain sight on your county's own website. A county that runs a building department lists it among its departments. A county that does not, does not. **The absence is the finding** — and it takes about ten minutes to establish.

The ten-minute method

1. Open your county's official site and find its Departments or Elected Officials index. Get the complete list, not the search box. Watch the domain: Arkansas counties use no consistent pattern — some are *.gov*, some *.com*, one uses *.ar.gov* — and several plausible-looking addresses are parked domains or private community sites rather than the county.

2. Read the whole list for a Building, Planning, Zoning, Permits or Development office. If the list runs Assessor, Circuit Clerk, Collector, Coroner, County Clerk, County Judge, Emergency Management, Road Department, Sheriff, Treasurer — and stops — there is no building department, and there is no building permit to pull.

3. Do not be fooled by three lookalikes. "Buildings and Grounds" is facilities maintenance for county-owned property. "Environmental Inspections" is usually stormwater and nuisance enforcement. "Emergency Management" often houses the floodplain administrator and 911 addressing — both of which you do need, neither of which is a building department.

4. Then ask the city anyway. A county mailing address does not mean you are outside municipal reach: cities have planning areas and extraterritorial jurisdiction. Ring the nearest city and ask whether your parcel is inside anything of theirs. This is the step people skip, and getting it wrong invalidates everything else.

5. Get the answer in writing and date it. Email is fine. Write it on the directory page at the end of this document. In three years, when an appraiser asks why there is no permit on file, that email is your answer.

WHAT THE METHOD RETURNED IN SEPTEMBER 2026

We ran it on five counties chosen to span the state. In every one, the county's own published department list contained no building, planning, zoning or permits office. **This is a snapshot, not a guarantee** — a quorum court can create a department at any time, so re-run the method on your own county rather than relying on this table.

Five counties, one result — verified from each county's own index

County	What its published department list shows
Garland Hot Springs	21 departments listed, none of them a building or planning office. Has Addressing, a Floodplain function under Emergency Management, a Road Department, and Environmental Inspections — which handles stormwater, not buildings
White Searcy	Assessor, Circuit Clerk, Collector, Coroner, County Clerk, Emergency Management, County Judge, Quorum Court, Road Department, Sheriff, Treasurer, Veteran Services. No building or planning office
Crawford Van Buren	Sixteen offices listed including 911 Communications and Emergency Management. No building, planning or permits office
Baxter Mountain Home	Has a "Buildings and Grounds" department — which maintains county-owned facilities and runs a work-order system. It is not a permit office. No building or planning department
Boone Harrison	Assessor, Circuit Clerk, Collector, County Clerk, County Judge, District Court, Emergency Management, Quorum Court, Road and Bridge, Treasurer, Veterans, Sheriff. No building or planning office

*Two warnings from running this ourselves. **A working web address is not proof of an official site:** at least two plausible county domains returned a normal page and were parked advertising domains, and one county-named site that looks entirely official is a privately run community and tourism site. Check for the county seal, the elected officials and a government domain. **And some counties have no website at all** — for one of the counties we tried, no official site exists to link to, which leaves the county courthouse as the only way in.*

THE OFFICES THAT EXIST WHEN NO BUILDING DEPARTMENT DOES

"No building permit" is not the same as "no paperwork." A rural Arkansas build still touches a short, specific list of offices. The real risk is not missing an agency — it is doing them in the wrong order, because two of them constrain where the house can physically sit.

The rural sequence

	Step	Which office, and why the order
1	Confirm nobody has jurisdiction	County department index, plus the nearest city's planning office. Do this before relying on any of it
2	911 address	Addressing coordinator, 911 Communications, or Emergency Management depending on the county. Early — utilities and often the septic permit need it
3	Septic permit	County health unit, through a licensed Designated Representative. Constrains the house position — do it before you fix the footprint
4	Water	A licensed well contractor, or the rural water association. No well permit exists; the construction standards still apply
5	Floodplain determination	County floodplain administrator, frequently inside Emergency Management. You may need a document certifying that you are <i>outside</i> the hazard area
6	Driveway or access permit	Decided by the road you touch: a state highway means the Department of Transportation; a county road means the county Road Department under the County Judge; a city street means the city
7	Electric service	Your utility or co-op — in practice the only electrical gate where no local permit program exists. Ask early
8	Utility locate	Arkansas 811, free, before any excavation
9	Stormwater	Only if total disturbance reaches one acre. Most single house sites do not
10	Assessor, afterwards	New construction goes on the rolls by itself. What you file is the homestead property tax credit — the deadline is 15 October

STATE-LEVEL ADDRESSES

All verified to resolve in September 2026. We print no phone numbers anywhere in this kit — they go stale faster than anything else on a printed page, and every office below can be reached from its own site.

What you actually need, and where it lives

To do this	Go here
Verify a contractor's license	labor.arkansas.gov — Arkansas Contractors Licensing Board, then <i>Find A Licensed Contractor</i>

What you actually need, and where it lives

To do this	Go here
Verify an electrician or HVACR license	labor.arkansas.gov — Department of Labor and Licensing rosters
Verify a plumber	Department of Health, not Labor and Licensing — adhplumbinghvaclookup.arkansas.gov
Apply for a septic permit	septictankpermitonline.adh.arkansas.gov
Find a Designated Representative	onsitewastewater.adh.arkansas.gov
Find your county health unit	healthy.arkansas.gov/health-units
Onsite wastewater rules and program	healthy.arkansas.gov — Onsite Wastewater
Water wells and licensed drillers	agriculture.arkansas.gov — Natural Resources Division
Floodplain management, state NFIP	agriculture.arkansas.gov — Floodplain Management
Check your flood zone	msc.fema.gov
Driveway onto a state highway	ardot.gov/permits — Access Driveway Permits
Construction stormwater	adeq.state.ar.us — Division of Environmental Quality. Note the old domain: the agency renamed, the address did not
State Fire Marshal	dps.arkansas.gov — Division of Emergency Management. Not the State Police, which is a different office
Homestead property tax credit	dfa.arkansas.gov — Assessment Coordination Division
Parcel and mapping data	gis.arkansas.gov
Utility locate before digging	ar811.org
Read the statutes	arkleg.state.ar.us — Arkansas Code
Read the agency rules	codeofarrules.arkansas.gov
Read the building code free	codes.iccsafe.org/codes/arkansas — Volume III is residential

YOUR DIRECTORY — FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Every office that touches this build, and what it told you

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	City — does it require a building permit for my parcel? Office _____ Answer _____ Date _____		

Every office that touches this build, and what it told you

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	County — does it require a building permit? Office _____ Answer _____ Date _____		
☐	Is the parcel inside a city planning area or extraterritorial jurisdiction? Confirmed with _____ Date _____		
☐	County health unit — Environmental Health Specialist Name _____ Unit _____		
☐	Designated Representative for the septic design Name _____ License _____		
☐	Septic installer, if not doing it myself Name _____ License _____		
☐	911 addressing office Office _____		
☐	County floodplain administrator Office _____		
☐	Road authority for my driveway — state, county or city Office _____		
☐	Electric utility or co-op, and its service requirements Name _____		
☐	Water — well contractor, or the rural water association Name _____		
☐	Plumbing permit and inspection authority — the utility body that serves this parcel Office _____		
☐	Electrical inspector, if anyone inspects here Name _____ License _____		

Every office that touches this build, and what it told you

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Building official, if one exists Name _____ Office _____		
☐	County assessor — for the homestead credit Office _____		

Because Arkansas publishes no register of permitting jurisdictions, the answers you write above are the only record that this question was ever asked. Date them, keep the emails behind this sheet, and re-check before you start any later phase — a quorum court or a city council can create a permit requirement between your foundation and your framing.